Is

Relation Without Time, Cause, or Rule

Matthew Parslow
Independent Researcher

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Abstract

One claim, made without machinery. To be is to stand in relation, and nothing further is required for there to be anything at all — no sequence, no cause, no rule about what may follow what. The companion accounts begin after this point and say so; this one supplies what they begin after. It is short because there is very little to say once the claim is stated, and that shortness is the argument.

1 The claim

What is, is. That is the whole of it, and everything below is an attempt to say what the sentence commits to and what it does not.

To be *something* rather than nothing at all is to be distinguishable, and to be distinguishable is to stand apart from something. *Distinction is relation.* There is no third option in which a thing is determinate and stands in no relation whatever: such a thing would differ from nothing, and a thing that differs from nothing is not a thing but the absence of one.

Proposition 1.1 (To be is to be related)**.** *Anything that exists as a determinate something stands in at least one relation. Equivalently: an existent bearing no relation is indistinguishable from non-existence, and the distinction between them is not available to be drawn.*

2 One is not enough

A single relatum with nothing to relate to is not a minimal case of existence but a failed one. There is nothing for it to be distinguished from, so there is no fact about what it is; it does not sit at the bottom of the hierarchy of existing things, it fails to enter. *One relatum is decoherent.*

The empty case is the other end and is cleaner. Nothing at all stands in no relation, has no parts to be in tension, and admits no failure of fit — it is complete in the only sense available to it. That is why the empty set is the only perfect thing and why perfection is not something an existent can have: *to exist is to be imperfect*, because to exist is to be related, and to be related is to be partial with respect to what one is related to.

3 What is not claimed

The claim above is smaller than it may appear, and the restraint is the point.

No time. Nothing here requires sequence. Relations hold; they do not happen. There is no earlier and no later in this paper, and no order in which anything is arrived at.

No cause. Nothing here makes anything else be. Relation is not production, and the account has no resources with which to say that one relatum brings about another.

No rule. Nothing here forbids anything or licenses anything. There is no admissibility, nothing that may or may not follow, and therefore nothing that could be violated.

Those three are not oversights and they are not deferred out of modesty. *They cost extra.* A world in which things also *happen* requires transformation and a grammar of what may follow what, and that is what the companion accounts introduce and pay for. This paper is what remains when they are removed, and it is offered as evidence that they are separable rather than constitutive.

4 Prior positions

None of this is new and it should not be dressed as though it were. That relations are prior to, or on a level with, their relata is the ontic structural realist position (Ladyman and Ross, 2007; Esfeld, 2004); that a thing is nothing over and above what it stands in is older than that and is stated more starkly elsewhere (Nāgārjuna, 1995); and the bundle tradition reaches a neighbouring conclusion by a different route (Williams, 1978).

What is contributed here is not the thesis but its *position*: that the thesis is enough on its own, that time and cause and rule are not required for it, and that an account of how things change can be built on top of it without folding any of the three back in. The companion papers are that account, and their first move is to assume this one.

5 Falsifiability

One commitment, and it is the only one this paper can carry.

1. [SHAPE] **To be is to be related.** Fails on the exhibition of an extant something standing in no relation whatever — not merely one whose relations are unknown or unmeasured, which is the ordinary condition of most things, but one for which the claim that it stands in any relation at all is false. The burden is entirely on that side: no enumeration establishes the claim, since the domain does not terminate, and one instance would bound it.

A second thing would count against the paper without falsifying the proposition, and is worth stating separately: if time, cause, or rule turned out not to be separable — if the account of change built on this one could not be constructed without folding one of them back into the base — then the restraint claimed in Section 3 would be a fiction and this paper would be an incomplete statement of the base rather than a minimal one.

References

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